

Concordia, via, humilitas:

Diagrammatic Method and the Understanding of History in Joachim of Fiore

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Can history be depicted by means of diagrams? Is it fully captured by what they apparently feature: names, numbers, visual elements? Or, inasmuch as there are large bodies of texts that these historical diagrams explain, must we also reckon with certain hermeneutical presumptions, which, despite their “invisibility” or indirect presence, should inform our understanding of history as mediated through the diagrams?

The present article will enquire into three such diagrams, which were devised by the Calabrian abbot Joachim of Fiore (c. 1135-1202). Through an in-depth analysis of these figures, and some of Joachim’s related works, it aims to show that Joachim’s diagrammatic and somewhat deterministic rendition of “historical facts” is susceptible to another interpretation as the “way of history”, unfolding through the exercise of freedom.

Introduction: concords and figures

There is broad agreement in contemporary research that the theological oeuvre of Joachim of Fiore hinges on a biblical-hermeneutical method that he called *concordia*.¹ The idea of *concordia*, that is, a particular approach to history in terms of a numerical harmony, was demonstrably present in his thought as early as the earliest extant sketches of his writing career, and then permeated his work to the very end. *Concordia* is a view of biblical and ecclesiastical history, which draws on the repeated appearance of certain relations, like those between persons, wars, and various kinds of events. It includes the ongoing reappearance of all kinds of such relations that can be laid bare as a recurrence of various number patterns, or, as Joachim himself puts it, “equal proportions”.

What may be viewed as a “geometric order” within Joachim’s understanding of history, clearly and fittingly emerges in those visual figures he designed all along the course of his theological work, and ultimately re-elaborated in an autonomous collection

¹ According to Herbert Grundmann, the great initiator of modern Joachim research, *concordia* is “the principle, on which his doctrine builds up” (*Studien über Joachim von Floris*. Leipzig: B.G.Teubner, 1927. 43.). One of the contemporary Joachim scholars, Gian Luca Potestà presents *concordia* in similar terms: he views it as the “architrave” of Joachim’s doctrine (*Il tempo dell’Apocalisse. Vita di Gioacchino da Fiore*. Roma-Bari: Laterza, 2004. 32.).

that is his final masterpiece, the *Liber Figurarum*.² Generally speaking, Joachim's *figurae* are like many other diagrams that were drawn in the Middle Ages, and have always been designed since Antiquity up until the present age: they are combinations of visual imagery with adjacent textual elements for scholarly or scientific explanatory purposes. What renders a visual image a diagram is its network of relations between distinct visual parts. By the addition of textual elements, which assign various references to them, the network formed by these parts and their relations corresponds to respective parts and relations in the concept or object that the diagram represents as a whole. As a consequence, the representative function of the parts is as distinct and definite as that of the whole. What especially contributes to the success of the whole and the parts in fulfilling this function are the numbers and numerical values represented by them. Indeed, there is a definitive characteristic of displaying countable elements and mediating quantitative values that is common to medieval figures as well as their modern counterparts. In Joachim's hands, the medieval genre of explanatory *figura* proves to be an appropriate instrument, which clearly represents the numerical harmony that he elaborated in his historical concords.

The basic characteristics of *concordia* and its diagrammatic representation feature clearly in the three figures that will be the major points of orientation in the present study. What is at first glance most striking in the 'Tree of the Two Advents' are the numerous branches, fanning out from the trunk in two distinct phases.³ While the whole image of the tree represents the whole biblical and ecclesiastical history of the world from Adam to the contemporary Popes and an imminent Second Advent of Christ, its twice twelve branches make up a *concordia* applicable to respective parts of the whole concept: the twelve tribes of Israel stemming from Jacob and the related twelve churches stemming from the First Advent (in accord with the number twelve of the disciples of Christ). As for the two other figures, the 'Trees of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia', they form a unity, and it is through the two of them that Joachim's concords reach their full historical span, although they demonstrably operate in the separate figures as well.⁴ In both figures, there is a symmetric and inverse correspondence between the two lines of the wandering of God's chosen ones through twice three historical shifts

² Cf. Marco Rainini, *Disegni dei tempi. Il Liber Figurarum e la teologia figurativa di Gioacchino da Fiore*. Roma: Viella, 2006. 20-21. The title used in modern scholarship (*Liber Figurarum*) originates from the *Chronica* of Salimbene of Parma.

³ See Leone Tondelli – Marjorie Reeves – Beatrice Hirsch-Reich, *Il Libro delle Figure dell'abate Gioacchino da Fiore*, vol. 2. Torino: S.E.I., 1953. TAVOLA II (FIGURE 1 at the end of the article).

⁴ See op.cit. TAVOLE XVI-XVII (FIGURES 2 and 3 at the end of the article).

from the humiliation of servitude to the glory of liberty and back. However, the multiple correspondences between the two figures amount to an even fuller *concordia*, which covers the whole of history. For instance, as the captions *Hur Chaldeorum/Chaldei (BABILON)* and *Babilonenses/Alamanni (ROMA)* serve as points of departure and also final stages among the eight compartments of each figure, it is from the Chaldean (Babylonian) Hur that Abraham sets out for his journey, and it is to the Babylon of the *Chaldei* that, many generations later, the chosen people would be forced to return in captivity; in like manner, it is from the power of the Babylonians, the “old Romans”, that the chosen ones come to be released, and it is to the “Rome” of the *Alamanni*, that is, to the new Roman Empire of the German Hohenstaufen dynasty that, in Joachim’s age, the Church as God’s new people would be forced to submit.⁵

Whatever we may understand now, or may recognise later, of the riches of these figures and of Joachim’s idea of *concordia*, it is already clear that they offer more than a demonstration of numerical harmony. Joachim employs his intricately elaborated numerical method in applying his biblical-historical knowledge to the Church and Papacy of his age and to an imminent future, in which he attaches particular significance to the struggle of the Popes with the German Emperors. Indeed, we may already conclude that his concept of *concordia* itself must be more than a curious obsession with numeric correspondences. Whether in the whole of Joachim’s oeuvre, or in his paradigmatic manifestation of it through visual figures, numerical concords necessarily include an interpretive dimension, which is, in most of the cases, tantamount to a political one.⁶

In exploring the complexities of Joachim’s understanding of *concordia*, it is illuminating to ask: what are the key premises of this term? Can we find visible traces of these premises in the diagrams themselves? As a matter of fact, the more or less shared symbolism of the Tree of the Two Advents and those of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia invokes a theme in Joachim’s legacy, which is most familiar to those who take an interest in the history of theology and particularly in that of the theology of history. Despite all their diagrammatic preoccupation with numbers and numerical demonstration, tree diagrams still preserve the powerful symbol of a tree. This would seem to be particularly appropriate to mediating Joachim’s well-known presumption that

⁵ Cf. Marjorie Reeves – Beatrice Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae of Joachim of Fiore*. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1972. 186-188.

⁶ Cf. Potestà’s remark about “la felice combinazione tra esegesi biblica e computo”: Potestà, loc. cit.

history should be a process of growth, progress, or development.⁷ Would the formula of historical progress, however, be as appropriate to the Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia figures as is to the Tree of the Two Advents? This is hardly the case, since, in contrast to the latter, the former ambiguously represent both liberation and subsequent submission on a double route, with Babilon and Rome as starting and terminal points. In so doing, they bear the striking marks of decline, too. Furthermore, it is clear that Joachim's familiar, apocalyptic approach to history in terms of an "imminent future" will hardly have the same meaning across these three figures. A vision of the future fixed upon Christ's imminent Second Advent finds no counterpart in the Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia figures but rather the prudent insight linked to the ROMA caption that "who descends here should hope for divine mercy" (*qui hic descendit speret misericordiam*). These latter tree figures show no unambiguous vision of growth but an ambivalent kind of progress, while, as we will see shortly, their employment of historical *concordia* is as full and thorough as in the Tree of the Two Advents.

The question raised about Joachim's general interpretive presumptions about the idea of *concordia* appears to be interrelated with the curious and exceptional character of his Trees of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia. These "trees" are exceptional, because they do not feature those minute genealogical lists and neither do they share the sweeping historical development that is so characteristic of Joachim's other tree diagrams or tree-like figures. Their trunks have no more than a purely visual and quasi-decorative function; their foliage is highly stylised, and, if they are susceptible to any linear reading, it implies a circular development. They lack the apocalyptic dimension and the radical eschatology of a new and final secular age, which are the best-known components of Joachim's legacy.⁸ What the curious Trees of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia suggest is, in any case, a process, a stage-by-stage movement all along the history of Israel and the Church.

In what follows I will take a closer look at Joachim's understanding of *concordia* and at his approach to his own tree figures (*arbores*) with the help of both his theological juvenilia, the *Genealogia*, and the major work of his later years, which bears the telling title *Liber de concordia novi et veteris testamenti*. I will pay particular attention to the ideas of

⁷ Beside being tools for diagrammatic demonstration, Joachim's figures retain the characteristics of symbolic images. Cf. Marco Rainini, "Gli alberi di Gioacchino da Fiore fra diagramma e simbolo", in: *Le monde végétal – Médecine, botanique, symbolique* (ed. Agostino Paravicini Bagliani). Firenze: Sismel – Edizioni del Galluzzo, 2009. 403-432.

⁸ See Gian Luca Potestà, "Ger 24 nell'interpretazione di Gioacchino da Fiore", in: *La cattura della fine – Variazioni dell'eschatologia in regime di cristianità* (ed. Giuseppe Ruggieri). Geneva: Marietti, 1992. 65-88, at 88.

progress, development and growth, which forms an integral part of most of Joachim's historical concords, especially the "arboreal" ones. Having gained a deeper insight into the concepts of *concordia* and *arbor* as based primarily on the Tree of the Two Advents, I shall proceed to a fuller understanding of the figures of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia. I will particularly enquire into Joachim's ideas of *transmigratio* and "the way to freedom" (*aditus libertatis*), that is, concepts, which do not necessarily imply the idea of growth that inhabits most of his tree concords. In order to do so, apart from the *Concordia*, I will turn to another two of Joachim's writings from the 1180s, the *Intelligentia super calathis plenis ficibus* and the *Dialogi de prescientia Dei et predestinatione electorum*. I shall then propose the concept of a historical way (*via*) and the notions of freedom (historical choice) and humility (*humilitas*) as possible answers to the question of what the necessary hermeneutical presumptions might be about Joachim's idea of *concordia* as reflected in his figures and particularly in the double perspective of the Tree of the Two Advents and the Trees of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia.

Concordia and Genealogia

Although the word *concordia* does not emerge even once in Joachim's earliest extant work, the idea itself is already thoroughly present. This work begins with the word *genealogia*, and with a sentence that uses the trunk of a tree as a central image for it (*stipes arboris*): "The genealogy of the ancient holy fathers that is woven from Adam to Jacob is the trunk of the tree."⁹ The combination of a genealogy with the image of a tree was already as self-evident for Joachim and his century as it is for us. It becomes clear, however, that Joachim's tree image means more than the cultural metonymy of a "genealogical tree".¹⁰ It is a rich metaphor, which, in the present case, does not intend just a single, but an intertwined double tree as an embodiment of the idea of *concordia*. What we believed to be a single tree in the figure of the Two Advents proves to be an image with the grafting of a vine into a fig tree.

The way this fig tree [sc. of the Old Testament] has a beginning, growth, and decay, so the other tree, namely the vine of the New Testament, that is, the Church, has its own beginning, growth, and decay. The

⁹ "Genealogia sanctorum antiquorum patrum textitur ab Adam usque ad Iacob, et hec stipes arboris dicitur." See Gian Luca Potestà, "Die Genealogia. Ein frühes Werk Joachims von Fiore und die Anfänge seines Geschichtsbildes", in *Deutsches Archiv für Erforschung des Mittelalters* 56 (2000), 91. Hereafter I will refer to Potestà's edition as *Genealogia*.

¹⁰ About the antique and medieval cultural tradition of genealogical trees in the context of the iconographical development of the Jesse Tree, see Arthur Watson, *The early iconography of the Tree of Jesse*. London: Oxford University Press, 1934.

beginning and sort of trunk of this vine is engrafted into the fig tree, since the Church has its beginning in the synagogue.¹¹

This idea of a double rhythm between two trees, and other various components of Joachim's description, appear to be neatly executed in the Tree of the Two Advents, although there was a lapse of quarter of a century between his verbal sketch of the former and his graphical design of the latter (the latter shows considerable differences in some details like, for instance, its lack of any features of a combination of a fig tree and a vine).

The key to the well-ordered unity of the trees of the Old and the New Testament lies in the way the numbers of generations belonging to each are divided and organised.

From the base of the trunk (*a stipite*) to Christ, the first tree contains sixty-three carnal generations; from the base of the second tree (*a stipite secunde arboris*) to the judging Christ, there are sixty-three spiritual generations; those middle ones, however, that are the final part of the first and the trunk of the second tree, are partly carnal, partly spiritual. Forty-two inferior generations are but carnal; forty-two superior ones are only spiritual. The inferior generations are designated by the names of the fathers, while the superior ones are designated by a sequence of number thirty (*numeris terdenariorum*). This is because, as it is generally held, the Church lasts over the same number of spiritual generations as the Synagogue over carnal generations.¹²

There are, therefore, twenty-one generations between the beginning of the Tree of the New Testament and the end of the Tree of the Old that are both "carnal" and "spiritual". Accordingly, the twenty-one generations designated by both names and numbers (that is, thirty years per generation, indicated by XXX) starts from the time of king Ozeah, under whose rule the prophet Isaiah started to preach the Gospel, which marks the beginning of the New Dispensation.

Apparently, the concept of *concordia*, of which Joachim formulated only a decade later an explicit definition, is already at work in the *Genealogia*, partly through the calculation of generations, partly by means of other numerical correspondences. While Joachim's definition of this concept as a "similitude of the Old and the New Testament based on equal proportions" fully implies a measurement by generations, it does not

¹¹ "Sicut autem hec arbor ficus initium habuit et profectum et defectum, ita et alia arbor, vitis scilicet novi testamenti, videlicet ecclesia, suum habet initium, profectum et defectum. Initium et quasi stipes huius vitis insertus est ficui, quia ecclesia initium habuit a sinagoga." *Genealogia*, loc. cit.

¹² "In prima arbore continentur a stipite usque ad Christum LXIII generationes carnales; a stipite secunde arboris usque ad Christum iudicem LXIII spirituales; verumtamen ille medie, que sunt finis prime et stipes secunde, partim carnales sunt, partim spirituales. XLII inferiores sunt tantum carnales, XLII superiores tantum spirituales. Inferiores designantur nominibus partum, superiores vero numeris terdenariorum. Putant enim, quod totidem generationibus spiritualibus duret ecclesia, quot carnalibus sinagoga." *Genealogia*, 92.

make any specific reference to it.¹³ Instead, his definition lays emphasis on the equivalence between “person and person, order and order, war and war”, which sounds like a conceptual focus on distinct historical protagonists and groups of them, and also on the historical events related to them. Accordingly, the salient double rhythm of 10+2 branches in the Tree of the Two Advents rests upon numeric proportions common to Israelite tribes and Christian churches. At the time of the patriarch Jacob, ten branches of ten tribes grow as side-branches, whereas the two tribes of Judah and Benjamin come to be represented as those making up the trunk and shooting sideways no earlier than the period of king Oziah, when the ten remaining tribes were “captured by the Assyrians” (*decem tribus ab Assiriis capte fuerunt*).¹⁴ In like manner, at the time of the First Advent of Christ, ten branches of ten churches grow sideways, whereas it is here the two churches of Rome and Ephesus that would constitute the trunk to become side branches only later, the branch of Rome representing the Latin church while the Ephesian branch represents the part of the Greek church that remained after the tribulation brought about by the Saracens.

The sweeping power (and also the limits) of Joachim’s historical concords receive an excellent illustration through the following text, which may also serve as an introduction to the Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia figures.

While events (*opera*) from Jacob to David, and from Christ to the end of Pope Sylvester’s rule, are thrown together in a confused way (*confusis hinc inde rebus*), as if tied up in a bundle regardless of any order based on a firm principle (*absque certe ordine rationis*), or any measure by generations, there are those that are similar in a way that the very ground of their concord is the equal number of generations (*sub tot et totidem generationibus*), over which they lasted in the course of obscure times.¹⁵

In other words, there would not be any order in the chaos of various historical periods without the method of *concordia* picking out some of the events in a well-ordered way. It remains to be seen, however, to what degree the “ground of the concords” lies in the number of generations. The passage continues as follows.

¹³ Cf. Abbot Joachim of Fiore, *Liber de Concordia Novi ac Veteris Testamenti*, Transactions of the American Philosophical Society, vol. 73 (ed. E. Randolph Daniel). Philadelphia: The American Philosophical Society, 1983. 62.

¹⁴ Cf. Tondelli – Reeves – Hirsch-Reich, *Il Libro delle Figure*, TAVOLA II (see FIGURE 1 at the end of the article).

¹⁵ “Igitur a Iacob usque ad David, et a Christo usque ad extrema tempora Silvestri pape, confusis hinc inde rebus et velut in fasciculo collegatis absque certe ordine rationis aut numero generationum, opera similia gesta sunt, ut videlicet hoc ipsum sit concordie causa quod sub tot and totidem generationibus obscura tempora transierunt.” *Liber de Concordia*, 324-325.

However, there are similar events (*opera*) that happened in both of the dark periods in a clearly distinguishable way. Besides what we know about Christ and the twelve disciples, I think we should recall from among them the great moments (*opus*) when, after the time of the twelve patriarchs, Moses and Aaron, who had been appointed for this task, led the people of Israel out of Egypt, and in like manner, after the twelve apostles, the Lord chose Paul and Barnabas to prepare the way for the people of the faithful leaving the synagogue of the Jews in order that, after crossing the desert of the Gentiles, they could enter the land flowing with milk and honey. In the way that the death of Moses gave way to the succession of Joshua, who divided their heritage into seven tribes, so Paul's withdrawal from the Asian region gave way to the succession of John who wrote the Book of the Apocalypse to the seven churches that were in it. During Joshua's lifetime, the sons of Israel occupied much of the land of the Canaanites; during St. John's lifetime, the faithful obtained much of the extensive possessions of the Gentiles. After Joshua's death, those Gentiles waged war against the sons of Israel many times, that is, up to the time of king David. After John's death, the Pagans fought against the Christians up to the time of St. Sylvester.¹⁶

What we are confronted with here are two correspondent orders of persons and events, the correspondence of which rests primarily upon their nature and also upon their numbers. Nevertheless, Joachim's narrative in his *Book on the Concords between the Old and the New Testament* is more than a demonstration of *concordia*, that is, more than that of an equality of numbers and a consecutive correspondence. Behind the list of all concords, there is a teleological presumption that these persons and events all point toward "the land flowing with milk and honey" or, to put it more precisely, toward the full possession of that land, which, according to Joachim, came true under the rule of King David and also under that of Pope Sylvester at the time of Constantine. However, this full possession did not turn out to be a final one as the Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia figures are clearly meant to show. The quote from Joachim's *Concordia* is able to illuminate roughly (but not entirely) the left sides, that is, the ascending sides, of these figures.

However superior Joachim's Tree of the Two Advents might be to his Trees of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia in rendering the ideas of historical growth,

¹⁶ "Gesta sunt tamen similia opera in utriusque tenebrosi temporis spatio satis clara, inter que illud magnum opus – postea que de Christo et duodecim apostolis dicta sunt – memorandum puto, quod sicut post duodecim patriarchas, Moyses at Aaron viri nominati eduxerunt populum Israel de Egypto, ita post duodecim apostolos, electi sunt a domino Paulus et Barnabas, qui prepararent viam populo fidei egressuro de synagoga Iudeorum ut, transeuntes per deserta gentilium, introirent in terram fluentem lac et mel. Sic et, obeunti Moysi, successit Iosue, qui divisit septem tribubus hereditatem, sic, recedenti Paulo a regione Asie, successit Iohannes, qui scripsit librum Apocalypsis septem ecclesiis, que fuerunt in ea. Vivente adhuc Iosue, possederunt filii Israel ex magna parte terram Chananeorum; vivente adhuc sancto Iohanne, optinuerunt ex magna parte fideles largas possessiones gentilium. Obeunte Iosue, conflixerunt gentes ille cum filiis Israel multo tempore, usque videlicet ad tempora David regis. Et, obeunte Iohanne, pugnauerunt pagani contra christianos usque ad tempora sancti Silvestri." Op.cit., 325.

progress, and development, there is at least one point at which the text of the *Genealogia* comes closer to the latter than to the former. Focused though the first part of the text might be on how to draw a twofold tree figure (*figura arboris*) in agreement with what its author wants us to understand, the related *tree image* from bottom to top is fundamentally different from the *life process of a tree* from beginning (birth) to end (decay) (as it is described in the very first passage that is on the beginning, growth, and decay of a fig tree and a vine). What the double figure of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia offers is less a twofold tree image to be viewed from an inferior bottom to a superior top (as the Tree of the Two Advents suggests), than a reference to the double life process of two subsequent trees. Both this double process and a kind of openness to further historical events are aspects common to the Trees of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia, and the passage from the *Genealogia* on the beginning, growth, and decay of a fig tree and a vine. The reference in the passage to *defectus* or decay opens up a possible future, which may include both a promise of growth as well as the decay of the descending sides and deepest points in the Trees of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia. Indeed, in such a future the two are connected: the first opens up the second, and the second also opens up the promise of growth with the statement that “who descends here should hope for divine mercy”. In these curious trees, there is no closed structure filled with generations of past, present, and future that we find in the Tree of the Two Advents. While the formulas of “growth” and “progress” perfectly fit the concords of the latter tree, the fundamental hermeneutical presumption behind those of the Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia figures appears to be significantly different.

Transmigratio and the way to liberation

What is most striking about the Trees of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia is their design, which, at first glance, makes them look like a “circular map”. Their compartments run around as *loci*, in a place-by-place movement, turning the end back to the beginning. It might appear even more alien to their tree-like visual characteristics that the Roma/Ecclesia figure contains something like two sides of a governing principle, which may prompt both figures to function like wheels rather than trees: the reference at the bottom to divine mercy after descent has a counterpart at the top referring to a threatening fall after ascent (*qui hic ascendit timeat ruinam*). And what emerges in both figures as a decorative reminder of a tree trunk serves the sole purpose of linking one of them with the Old Testament through the caption ADAM, and the other with the New Testament through the caption OZIAS (which fully coincides with the beginnings of the two Testaments in both the *Genealogia* and the Tree of the Two Advents).

It was exactly this circular character and its consequence, the missing representation of any historical end scenario, that captured Marjorie Reeves' attention as a key aspect in these diagrams, given their unusual character in relation to Joachim's oeuvre as a whole.¹⁷ Indeed, the lack of the representation of the end, the *eschaton*, is unusual in the context of Joachim's thought, especially if one puts it against the background of his *Liber de Concordia* as Reeves did. She found there a passage, which offers a nearly complete explanation of the Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia figures. Drawing upon this passage, she could confidently interpret these figures as representing the necessity of a historical process, in arguing that their pair of seven *loci* "mark out the historical relationships between the journeying People of God and the successive earthly rules, to which they must submit."¹⁸ A major part of Joachim's passage reads as follows:

If this is the case, and it is clear enough that the rule of Babylon preceded the rule of the Egyptians, while the rule of the Egyptians the rule of Jerusalem, why is it that, in turn, after the rule of David and his sons the king of Egypt and finally the king of Babylon dominated over Jerusalem, if not for the reason that, as it came from darkness to light through the Son of God, the people of the faithful will for its sins come from light to the captivity of darkness by the coming of the son of perdition, so that, as the prophet says, "for now shalt thou go forth out of the city, and thou shalt dwell in the field, and thou shalt go even to Babylon" (Micah 4, 10).¹⁹

Applying a symmetric concordance between the Old and the New Testament and also to two further pairs of earthly rules that were added through the two figures, we can fairly conclude with Reeves that both the quote and the figures view Israel and the Church as "journeying" over two concordant sequences of earthly rules with liberation at their peak as follows: Babylon, Egypt, Syria and the Philistines, the sublimation of Jerusalem, Syria and the Philistines, Egypt, Babylon; and again, Rome (Babylon), Jews, Pagans, the sublimation of the Church, Goths, Galls (Franks), Rome (Germans). Nevertheless, the reference in the quote to the end as the apocalyptic coming of the Antichrist (the son of perdition) thoroughly differs from the allusion to a future rise by divine mercy in the

¹⁷ Cf. her full analysis in Marjorie Reeves – Beatrice Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae*, 184-191.

¹⁸ Op. cit., 188.

¹⁹ "Que cum ita se habeant et constet modis omnibus quod regnum Babilonis precessit regnum Egyptiorum, regnum vero Egyptirum regnum Iherusalem, quid est quod e converso post regnum David et filiorum eius prevaluit rex Egypti contra Iherusalem, et ad ultimum rex Babilonis; nisi quod sicut per Filium dei actum est ut de tenebris fidelis populus veniret ad lucem, ita, appropinquante filio perditionis, de luce pro peccatis suis captivetur ad tenebras, ut secundum illud propheticum 'egressus de civitate habitet in regione, et exinde ducatur usque ad Babilonem'" *Liber de Concordia*, 377.

figure of the New Dispensation, the minimalism of which Reeves is eager to contrast with Joachim's famous idea of a third and final age as a culmination of history.

However, the quote from the Book of the Prophet Micah brings about a nexus between the above quoted passage and further ones from Joachim's works, which, as a more complete background to them, gives the Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia figures a fuller meaning. This nexus in Micah significantly coincides with a group of texts that Gian Luca Potestà identified as dealing with the ambiguous historical process of liberation instead of the progressive eschatology of a third and final age.²⁰ In Joachim's understanding, the process of liberation cannot be fulfilled but by a way leading through servitude: the *transmigratio Babilonis* as the grievous way through a new Babylonian captivity to a future political liberation became a painful experience for the Church of Joachim's age in its struggle with the new Roman Empire of the German rulers. The political alternative of the Church as God's new people, between freedom at the top and servitude at the bottom of an imaginative wheel of history, is able to explain what the passage quoted from the *Liber de concordia* was unable to do: the captions referring to the threat of fall at the top, and to the prospect of a rise at the bottom of the Roma/Ecclesia figure.

The work in which Joachim gave the fullest account of his approach to the situation of the Roman Church in the mid 1180's is his letter written against the anti-imperial faction, commonly referred to as *The understanding of the baskets full of figs* (*Intelligentia super calathis plenis ficubus*). More specifically, the letter contains Joachim's stance in his controversy with the Cistercian abbot Geoffrey of Auxerre over the application of a passage in the Book of Jeremiah to the contemporary power struggle between the Pope and the Emperor. In contrast to Geoffrey, Joachim suggested that Pope Urban III submit to Emperor Frederick Barbarossa in their conflict, which originated from the inheritance of the kingdom of Sicily and escalated over the investiture of the Archbishop of Trier. When in the year 1186, Frederick backed his own candidate against the one supported by the Pope, and a marriage between the Emperor's son, Henry, and the daughter of the Norman king of Sicily, Constance, threatened the Papacy by getting it caught in crossfire between the North and South, Joachim chose Jeremiah's allegory of the fig baskets to influence the political decision-making of the papal court. In so doing, he compared this major crisis of his time to the situation in

²⁰ Cf. Potestà, "Ger 24 nell'interpretazione di Gioacchino da Fiore", 88. n. 67, and Ioachim Abbas Florensis, *Dialogi de prescientia Dei et predestinatione electorum* (ed. Gian Luca Potestà), Roma: Istituto Storico Italiano, 1995. 122. n. 18. Beside the passage from the *Liber de concordia novi et veteris testamenti* and other passages from the *Intelligentia super calathis plenis ficubus* and the *Dialogi de prescientia Dei and predestinatione electorum* (that I will interpret in what follows), this group of texts also includes some of Joachim's *Sermones*.

Palestine in 587 B.C., as reflected in Chapter 24 of the Book of Jeremiah. As Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, occupied Jerusalem and took its king, Jeconiah, and a major part of its population into exile, those who remained in the city maintained the kingdom of Judah under the rule of the king's brother, Zedekiah. As a result, Judah and Jerusalem were split into two parts, and, as it were, into two parties which were not equally favoured by God. The prophet Jeremiah viewed those in exile as God's chosen ones, in the image of a basket of good figs, while his corresponding image of the basket of bad figs stands for those who remained in Jerusalem and, in defiance of God's will, sought armed liberation against Babylonian rule. Accordingly, Joachim makes use of Jeremiah's imagery to draw a sharp distinction between those in the papal court who suggest armed resistance against the imperial power and those who advise temporary submission to the emperor. What Joachim's letter wishes to prove by all rhetorical means is that only the choice made by the latter group opens a viable way forward for the Roman Church in the mid 1180s.²¹

Although the method centred on symmetric historical concords between earthly empires is as present here in the *Intelligentia* as it was in the *Liber de Concordia*, the former also elaborates on what may be called the idea of historical choice, which is complementary to Joachim's view of history as rolling forward in accordance with numerical correspondences.²² The *Intelligentia* begins with an exposition of Joachim's method of *concordia* before shifting its focus onto the passage of Micah about the *transmigratio Babilonis*, and especially onto its related promise of liberation from Babylon: "and thou shalt go even to Babylon; there shalt thou be delivered; there the Lord shall redeem thee from the hand of thine enemies" (4, 10). What the following quote unfolds is not only the historical way, as it were, from freedom through servitude to freedom, but also the freedom of choice in the course of this way, which thereby comes to be rendered in a more differentiated way than a development conceived as a repetition of "equal proportions".

The reason why those who are free must go to Babylon is not simply that they should be set free again there; if, however, it happens so, they should mourn that they lost God's grace, but in a way that they do not lose hope in the mercy of the Saviour. Now someone may raise an objection and say: "If this is so, why does God give his servant into the hand of the enemy, so that he is taken to Babylon?" But, whoever

²¹ On the biblical and historical background of Joachim's interpretation of Jer 24, see Potestà, *Il tempo dell'Apocalisse*, 191-218. Cf. McGinn, *The Calabrian Abbot*, Joachim of Fiore in the History of Western Thought, New York: MacMillan, 1985, 4-5, and 12-13.

²² It is important to note, however, that another locus in the *Liber de Concordia* makes a further allusion to the major themes of *Intelligentia*: see *Liber de Concordia*, 386.

may raise this question, let him tell me, why does God allow the temptation of someone, about whom God knows he is to be defeated and indeed led away to Babylon? Well, I will satisfy this person with an answer to this question by showing that humble servitude is better than haughty freedom, that is, not better than humble freedom but than that which is haughty; it is not better than the overthrown rule but the exalted one. Who is so insane not to prefer a humble virgin to someone who is penitent but corrupt? And who is as averse to salvation as not to prefer a corrupt penitent to a foolish, haughty virgin? The haughty virgin should therefore mourn if taken to Babylon in her corruption, and she should know that she can stand only if she humbles herself and learns to love, since, even if unwilling, she will be taken to Babylon by just judgement, as happened to Zedekiah, the king of Judah; and she should also know that there is as much difference between the haughty virgin and the one who converted from her sins, and is already taken to Babylon, as between the bad figs and the good figs, for the former remains lofty only to fall, while the latter remains low, and has already begun to rise.²³

The *transmigratio Babilonis* proves to be a way to freedom and liberation (*aditus libertatis*) less through the divine execution of an objective historical order (which, nevertheless, retains its reality and relevance) than through the inner drama of choice and decision to be made by those who face the painful way to Babylon (which means the power and dominion of the German emperor). The ambivalent perspectives of fall and rise make it hard to maintain the idea of progressive development as a necessary component in Joachim's view of history.

What follows from this instructive passage as to the understanding (*intelligentia*) of Jeremiah's parable of the "baskets full of figs"? Firstly, it clearly shows that the reason why the people of God (the "haughty virgin") must be taken to Babylon "is not simply that they should be set free again there" in a vicious circle of the historical process. Neither is this transmigration a spiral-like movement, which would combine a historical return with a coinciding development. What we have here is the shock of a historical fall (called *confusio*), which implies very little like growth, progress, or development. It is through this fall, at least in the case of those who go to Babylon by humbling themselves

²³ "Non enim est eundem in Babilonem his, qui liberi sunt, ut ibi iterum liberentur; sed si contingat, lugeant propter perditam gratiam, non ita tamen ut desperent de misericordia redemptoris. Opponat aliquis et dicat: 'Et si ita est, quare tradit Dominus servum suum in manu hostis, ut tradatur in Babilonem?' Sed dicat mihi, quicunque est ille, quare permisit hominem temptari, quem sciebat prostrandum et ducendum revera in Babilonem? et ego illi satisfaciam super questione ista, ostendens meliorem servitutem humilem libertate superba: superba, inquam meliorem, non humili, elata, non prostrata potenti. Quis enim tam insanus ut non preferat humilem virginem penitenti corrupte? Et quis tam alienus a salute ut non preferat penitentem corruptam virgini fatue et superbe? Lugeat ergo superba virgo si corrupta ducetur in Babilonem, sed sciat se omnino stare non posse nisi humilietur et diligat, quia iusto iudicio ducetur vel invita in Babilonem, sicut Sedechias rex Iuda, tantumque distare inter superbam virginem ex peccato conversam et quasi in Babilonem iam positam, quantum inter ficus malas et ficus bonas, quia illa manet in alto ut corruat, ista manet in imo et elevari iam cepit." Pietro de Leo, *Gioacchino da Fiore – Aspetti inediti della vita e delle opere*, Rubbettino Editore, 1988. 139-140.

(and who are the “basket of the good figs”), that the way of the *transmigratio* will imply a historical return in agreement with the circular design of the Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia figures.

Secondly, the double way represented by the two opposite baskets in Jeremiah’s parable implies an inescapable choice. What is particularly telling in this regard is the mere existence of the alternative basket of the bad figs, while both baskets represent the same in the objective terms of the historical way to Babylon. Indeed, their alternatives are also indicative of another alternative to these “objective terms”. In the quoted passage, the outward up and down of history (*libertas, servitudo, virginitas, corruptio*) is profoundly interwoven with a kind of inward up and down (*humilitas, superbia*). Beyond the “outward” or “objective” historical position of a person or a group, there also exists an inward way, in which this person or group relate to their outward position. This inward way is also a relation to God as regards this position. And it is not only the alternative ways in haughty *libertas*, that is, a stubborn haughtiness (Zedekiah and the bad figs) and the haughtiness that comes to humble itself (Jeconiah and the good figs), that makes a difference. In terms of an inward relationship with God, the “objectively” inescapable *transmigratio Babilonis* involves alternative ways in the humiliation of *servitudo* too. In sharing with Joachim’s *Intelligentia* this matrix of outward and inward relations, his *Dialogi de prescientia Dei* (which also elaborates on the quote from Micah) lays an even greater emphasis on the admonition of *Noli desperare!* (“Do not despair!”) in the midst of God’s punishment that is the Babylonian captivity. In the midst of defeat and captivity where one may raise the question of “why does God give his servant into the hand of the enemy, so that he is taken to Babylon?”, the temptation of despair is still great, and it makes a great difference as to what kind of answer the “humiliated virgin” gives to it.

Conclusion: *Via, concordia* and *humilitas*

Joachim’s *Intelligentia super calathis* and *Dialogi de prescientia Dei* outline an understanding of the way of history (which is called *via, iter* or “*aditus*” in his works) as a place of free choice, without withdrawing his fundamental approach to this way as a *concordia* of numerical correspondences. In their own way, the ideas of both *concordia* and historical freedom are present in the figures of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia, which, retaining the basic design of correspondences and historical necessity, derive major inspiration from the conflict between the Papacy and the Empire over Sicily and the archbishopric of Trier. In drawing upon the turmoil at the papal court in the mid 1180s, the geometric order of these figures can carry the idea of a historical turn, which implies both a fall and a rise. Instead of presenting a mere map of an historical development, the

curious 'Trees of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia, with their descending and ascending branches, imply a call for a decision, and their viewers' response to it must form part of their understanding of the figures.

According to his *Intelligentia super calathis* and *Dialogi de prescientia Dei*, Joachim's way of history implies not only a well-ordered sequence of events (which is a basic presumption of the concept of *concordia*), but also a moment of choice and freedom that is expressed in his notion of humility. Just as *concordia*, as a way of understanding history, is foundational to Joachim's thought, so is his concept of a historical way. Both of them are an understanding (*intelligentia*) of history, but the former implies and presupposes the latter. Joachim's *concordia* implies and presupposes his *via*, which, as an *intelligentia* or a view of history, includes the moment of freedom in terms of the viewer's or interpreter's response to the concords or, more generally, the order of history.

When, in his *Liber de concordia novi et veteris testamenti*, explicitly reflecting upon his constellation of *via*, *concordia*, and *intelligentia*, Joachim unites them into an integrated perspective, which explicitly does not include his view of *humilitas* as the "way to freedom" (*aditus libertatis*), that is, the insight he gains in his *Intelligentia super calathis*.

The understanding that is called concordia is like a continuous way leading from the desert to the city (...).²⁴

This quote does not consider the opposite way to freedom from the city through the desert and captivity, as based on the biblical reference to the prophet Micah. Here it is from the desert to the city that the way of history proceeds. However, before dedicating the whole passage to the images of growth, progress and development, he adds that

there are lower places along the way, where the traveller hesitates as to how to find the right direction, while there are also mountain heights on his way, where he can have an overview of where he comes from and where he goes, and measure the right direction of the rest of his route through the contemplation of the way he has already gone.²⁵

What emerges here as a basic presumption about the concept of *concordia* is an order of history as a continuous way (*via continua*), which allows for an uneven process, although this process draws here on a "cognitive unevenness" rather than on "falls and rises"

²⁴ "Intelligentia vero illa, que concordia dicitur, similis est vie continue que a deserto porrigitur ad civitatem..." *Liber de Concordia*, 66.

²⁵ "...interpositis locis humilioribus in quibus se viator ambigat iter rectum adire, et nichilominus interpositis iugis montium a quibus possit posteriora et anteriora respicere et residui itineris rectitudinem ex retroacte vie contemplatione metiri." Loc. cit. This locus has also been quoted and interpreted in Barbara Obrist, "Image et prophétie au XIIe siècle: Hugues de Saint-Victor et Joachim de Flore", in *Mélanges de l'Ecole française de Rome, Moyen-Age – Temps modernes* 98 (1986), 35-63, at 57.

because of the inner conflict of freedom. Nevertheless, an understanding of history, which includes “lower places” of hesitation about “the right direction” may also imply this inner conflict. The problem of the proper cognition of history and that of historical choice as a “pro or contra” are inseparable.

The more foundational view of a *via continua* of history is as present in the Tree of the Two Advents and the Trees of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia as it is the more elaborated historical concords. The three images in question may also be regarded as some of those “mountain heights” which, as tools of orientation to those who are crossing “lower places”, provide a comprehensive insight into the whole of the historical way. It is the underlying view of a continuous way that operates as a foundation upon which the figures can elaborate the numerical correspondences of *concordia*.

What may be considered as an essential dimension of the understanding (*intelligentia*) of a *via continua* mediated through the Tree of the Two Advents and the figures of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia is the historical freedom that Joachim articulates as an alternative between *humilitas* and *superbia* with regard to this historical way. While this appeal to choice is clearly present in the figures of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia, which feature both ascending and descending branches, it is, no doubt, difficult to see how this appeal could relate to the Tree of the Two Advents, with its striking imagery of growth, progress, and development. Any choice would not seem to make any difference in this sweeping vision of historical development. However, the choice in question is not supposed to change anything in the objective order and the numerical correspondences of the continuous way, which is an understanding common to the Tree of the Two Advents and the figures of Babilon/Jerusalem and Roma/Ecclesia. Whether she has faith in a new rise or she loses all hope in God’s mercy, the haughty virgin must go to Babylon, and the viewer, who is also a historical protagonist, a “traveller”, must inevitably face the final tribulations and the final moment of decline that, in spite of the growth and progress inherent in its imagery, form part of the Tree of the Two Advents.²⁶

It is, however, not only single details of the historical way as mediated through these figures that imply freedom and require humility on the part of the interpreter. Joachim’s holistic figures and the “mountain heights” of the historical way have in common that they make traveller and viewer coincide: helped by these figures like those “heights”, someone who otherwise only participates in history is given an overview of

²⁶ In its description of the vine tree of New Testament times, Joachim’s *Genealogia* makes a reference to a final decay, which is likely to be in agreement with the final tribulation by the Antichrist. Cf. *Genealogia* 95-96.

the whole of the historical *via*. The mediation of a holistic view of history is a key characteristic of Joachim's diagrammatic method as based on the numerical correspondences of *concordia*, which cover a historical totality from the beginning to the end. It is hard to say in what sense such an overview offered to human travellers differs from God's own omniscient view of the whole. Many theologians would justifiably reject Joachim's diagrammatical method on account of a holistic kind of knowledge that his figures mediate in rendering simple travellers (like those at the papal court in the mid 1180s), as it were, omniscient viewers. If there is any legitimacy to the view of history mediated by these figures, it must come from an appeal to human viewers to be humble when facing history in its totality.

We must see that the appeal which the figures make for *humilitas* implies a very limited kind of free choice, which only includes the theological alternatives of a humble and a haughty attitude to the overview of the whole, as well as insight into the meaning of the periods of suffering in God's historical order. But this limited choice suffices to show a necessary presumption, inherent to Joachim's diagrammatic method. What his figures mediate are not only historical concords but also the understanding of a historical *via* and a basic hermeneutical attitude of humble acceptance.